

Maharishi Charaka – Contributions to Medicine and Ayurveda

Maharishi Charaka is called the **Father of Medicine** in Ayurveda. His major work, the **Charaka Samhita**, systematized Ayurvedic knowledge into a scientific system covering diseases, diagnosis, treatment, diet, pharmacology, and medical ethics.

1. Charaka Samhita – Structure

- One of the oldest medical texts in the world; written in Sanskrit
- Divided into 8 sections (Sthanas):

Section (Sthana)	Content
Sutra Sthana	Basic principles of Ayurveda
Nidana Sthana	Diagnosis of diseases
Vimana Sthana	Medical studies and standards
Sharira Sthana	Anatomy and embryology
Indriya Sthana	Symptoms and prognosis
Chikitsa Sthana	Treatment methods
Kalpa Sthana	Preparation of medicines
Siddhi Sthana	Successful treatment methods

2. Ayurveda as a Scientific System

- Charaka emphasized observation, logical reasoning, experimentation, and careful diagnosis
- Stated: "Prevention is better than cure" – maintaining health is more important than treating disease

3. Theory of Tridosha

- **controls movement and nervous functions:** Vata
- **controls digestion and metabolism:** Pitta
- **controls strength and stability:** Kapha
- Balance of the three doshas = good health; imbalance = disease

4. Diet and Digestion

- Wrong food habits cause many diseases; food itself can act as medicine
- Principles: eat fresh and balanced food, avoid overeating, eat according to body type and season
- Maintain digestive fire (Agni) – key to health

5. Human Anatomy and Physiology

- Studied bones, muscles, heart, digestive organs, and body tissues (Dhatus)
- Described body immunity – called Ojas

6. Diagnosis

- Methods: observation of symptoms, pulse and body examination, patient questioning, studying digestion/sleep/habits

- Correct diagnosis considered essential for successful treatment

7. Herbal Medicine and Pharmacology

- Described hundreds of medicinal plants, herbs, and mineral preparations
- Classified medicines by taste, effect, potency, and digestive action
- Treatment types: herbal medicines, diet control, detoxification, lifestyle correction

8. Preventive Healthcare

- Follow daily routine (Dinacharya) and seasonal routine (Ritucharya)
- Maintain cleanliness, exercise regularly, control emotions and stress

9. Medical Ethics

- Physician should be: knowledgeable, disciplined, compassionate, and maintain cleanliness
- Doctors instructed to treat patients honestly and keep patient information confidential